

RECALCULATING

As rewarding as ministry can be it carries with it a plethora of challenges. Tonight I want to talk about one specific challenge: Reconnecting with family.

All of us know our priorities in life and ministry should be:

- #1 God...
- #2 Family...
- #3 Ministry...

We are great when it comes to preaching these priorities but we struggle with how to live them out in real time. We only have 24 hours in a day and how we do all that is required of us in ministry and keep the priority of our relationship to God and the relationship to our family in proper perspective becomes a mammoth challenge.

When I have my GPS on the voice mode and I do not obey it exactly, it will tell me to make a u-turn and if I do not heed HER instructions it will say “*Wait a moment, recalculating.*” There comes a moment in all of our lives, no matter how large or small the ministry that we have to recalculate. (Trip to Disneyworld – Susan – Do you like being a husband? Father? Pastor?)

I want to look at two families whose priorities were polar opposites and the results are unavoidable.

King David

David the son of Jesse was moved from obscurity to the throne by the hand of the Lord. David is undisputedly the greatest King to ever sit on a throne. He was “*A man after Gods own heart.*” The word of God prophesies that when Christ returns to the earth He will “*Sit upon the throne of David.*”

Yet, when you dig into David's personal and family life some very ugly things begin to surface:

- David committed adultery...
- David murdered Uriah...
- David's son, Amnon raped his half-sister Tamar...
- Because of her shame Tamar lived the rest of her life as a recluse in the house of her full-brother Absalom...
- David refused to enact any kind of justice against Amnon for Tamar's rape... (His inaction was probably a result of guilt for his own sin against Bathsheba and Uriah)
- Absalom avenged the rape of his sister Tamar by killing Amnon...

When Absalom killed Amnon he found himself banished from the king's presence and living in exile for three years. During this time the king refused to see him or

speak to him. Eventually Joab works a deal for Absalom to move back to the royal city but still the king refused to see or talk to his son.

Eventually Absalom petitions Joab three times to see the king but was refused. In the course of time Absalom was invited before the king. This is where it really gets weird – The king kissed Absalom but refused to speak to him or hold a conversation with him.

From this point the dye was cast, Absalom's inability to establish a relationship with his father would be the impetus for his rebellion that would lead to an attempted hostile takeover by Absalom.

We have heard a lot of preaching and teaching about Absalom's rebellion and people having an Absalom spirit. this entire scenario was the result of a father refusing to

discipline a son who was guilty of murder and refusing to talk to a son who engaged in vigilante justice.

Absalom sat at the gate of the palace and spoke with the people who were coming and going and said, ***“Your claims are good and right but there is no one appointed by the king to hear you. If I were king all who had a problem could come to me and I would give them justice.”*** Did you get that? His pain of not being able to have a relationship with his own father drove Absaloms rebellion.

When we place ministry above our families we create a seething anger within our children, against God and ministry.

No matter what has gone down in our families we must keep the lines of communication open. The church can get another pastor but your family cannot get

another father or mother. I have told CT Church repeatedly, *“I love you dearly, but if there is ever a time that I have to choose between my family and you, you will lose 100% of the time.”*

When Absalom was killed as a result of his rebellion against the king David sat in the chamber over the gate and wept saying, *“Absalom, Absalom, my son Absalom, would to God I had died for you!”* Absalom didn't need a father to die for him, he needed a father to talk to him and guide him.

Where have we placed our family in our list of priorities?

Obed Edom

When David decided to move the Ark to Jerusalem he built a new cart and began the process of transporting this Holy piece of furniture. The Ark was supposed to be

carried on the shoulders of the priests not on a cart.

Eventually the oxen stumbled and it appeared the cart would fall to the ground so a man by the name of Uzzah reached out to steady the Ark and he was struck dead right then and there for touching the Ark.

When Uzzah died David asked Obed-Edom if he could leave the Ark at his house. David wasn't just asking for a place to park the Ark, he was asking if Obed would do what needed to be done to attend the Ark. In effect he was saying "*Can we trust you with this Ark?*"

Against the backdrop of the death of Uzzah, wouldn't we be a little more than reluctant to have the Ark parked at our house? There is no sign of hesitation on the part of Obed, he was not afraid to receive the Ark.

Obed knew that a man with clean hands and a pure heart had nothing to fear from the Lord.

While the Ark was in the possession of the Philistines it brought curses; when it was in the custody of Abinadab it never seemed to bring a blessing or a curse; but when Obed-Edom hosted the Ark, it blessed him and his entire house!

The ark of God, that overthrew Dagon and smote Uzzah, was nothing but a fountain of blessing in the household of Obed-Edom.

What was the difference? The attitude and priority with which Obed-Edom cared for the Ark, released the blessing from the storehouse of God. Can we leave this Ark with you? Will you give it priority?

In a three-month period the fortunes of Obed's house took a drastic turn:

- His house turned from poverty to prominence... (God is El Shaddai not El Get-by!)
- He became a man of honor rather than being despised... (Obed means slave – Every time someone called him by his name it was a painful reminder of who he was – The name Edom was assigned to him because he was an Edomite and a descendent of Esau - He was a “Gittite” this means that he was from the city of Gath, the place of David’s greatest enemy, Goliath.)
- Obed and his family became addicted to the presence of God...

Because he gave the Ark proper respect and ordered his family right, Obed reversed the curse, found his destiny, and created a generational blessing for his family.

The day came that David returned to retrieve the Ark. Obed had a choice to make:

- Go back to his old way of life...
- Grieve the absence of the Ark...
- Pack up and follow the Ark...

When David came to take the Ark to Jerusalem Obed and his house left all and followed the Ark!

This was an easy choice for Obed; he would give up his life and livelihood and follow the presence of God. In so doing his attitude, actions, and aspirations created a legacy of faith, and relationship with the Lord. The Lord was faithful back to Obed-Edom establishing a legacy of generational blessings.

Obed Edom:

- Became the keeper of the gate at the Temple...
- Became a singer and musician in the house of the Lord...
- Became the keeper of the treasury...

What does each of these responsibilities have in common? Each job change moved him closer to the Ark!

His addiction to the presence of God caused **Obed Edom** to pass down a generational blessing to his offspring. He **had 62 descendents that** are all called blessed of God and **served in the temple! (PUT ALL THESE TOGETHER TO MAKE ONE SENTENCE)**

CONCLUSION:

If we are going to engage in ministry and raise Godly families we must:

- Make God the priority...
- Become actively involved in leading our families...
- Teach our children to pursue the presence of God...
- Demonstrate that serving God and His Church is an honor rather than an

obligation... ***“He has counted us
worthy placing us in the ministry.”***

I call every minister and ministers wife in this place to recalibrate the priorities of our lives. We know what our priorities should be but we must hit the reset button from time to time.